

## THE RISK OF GOING TO WORK

While many people are currently working from home due to COVID-19, there are many others who are still going to work every day to keep essential businesses and services running. Health-care professionals are on the front line, working tirelessly to help those who have the virus, as well as those with other health problems. Grocery-store employees work to keep shelves well-stocked and provide necessities for their customers. Delivery personnel are working overtime as more people place their orders online. In today's climate, these workers should be highly favored and valued for their willingness to put themselves at risk simply by doing their jobs.

### The Struggle Is Real

While COVID-19 is a pandemic affecting all people in the United States in a multitude of ways, communities of color are some of the most devastated. A recent documentary, *The Color of COVID*, highlights how the virus has spread quickly in these areas due to the disproportionate numbers of individuals with low-wage jobs for essential businesses and the lack of preventive supplies, such as masks, gowns, and gloves. With so many underinsured and underemployed, the effects of COVID-19 are overwhelming.

### The Luxury of Social Distancing

For those who are able to work from home during this time or do not have work responsibilities, there are several ways to honor the essential workers. We can show gratitude in our interactions with them and act to make sure they are equipped with the necessary safety equipment to stay healthy. Citizens can contact their legislators to make sure employees are cared for during these trying times and, once this pandemic has passed, we can make sure those who have lost their lives are honored in our local communities. Social distancing may seem annoying to most of us, but if we recognize it as a luxury, we will have a deeper respect for those who are taking a risk each day they go to work.

**What is one sacrificial act you can offer this week  
out of love for God?**



## TIP FOR THIS ISSUE

If you are serving teenagers with parents who continue to work outside the home, reach out to them personally this week to see how they are doing. Older teens may be providing child care for younger siblings, or they may have taken on increased household responsibilities during this time due to their parents' work schedules. Also teens may be working to complete schoolwork in a new way and dealing with the effects of their own social isolation. Make sure youth are taking care of their basic needs and remind them you are available to listen and talk when they need to vent.

# TEACHER BIBLE PREP



## RISKY BUSINESS

**Question of the Day:** What are you willing to risk for others?

**Purpose:** To help teens recognize the risk many people are facing to keep essential parts of our country working.

**Cultural Connection:** Essential Employees at Risk

**Topic:** Weighing Risks

## STEPPING OUTSIDE YOUR COMFORT ZONE

**Philippians 2:19-30**

*He risked his life and almost died for the work of Christ, and he did this to make up for the help you couldn't give me.*

—Philippians 2:30

### Commentary:

As he wrote his letter to the Philippian church, Paul was under house arrest (either awaiting his trial or its verdict) for preaching about Christ. The congregation in Philippi wished to support Paul in his time of need, so they gathered supplies and sent Epaphroditus to deliver them to his home. After this long journey, Epaphroditus became ill. Once he recovered, he returned to Philippi carrying Paul's letter, the book we know today as Philippians.

Doing God's work sometimes involves taking a step or two out of our comfort zone. It could even entail putting one's health or well-being on the line. No one said our Christian walk would be easy. We need to be willing to weigh the risks and be faithful to God's call.

### Questions to think about:

- ▶ What service do you feel God has called you to do for God's kingdom?
- ▶ What risks are involved in this call to service?
- ▶ Is there anything God is calling you to do that you haven't done yet because of the risk involved?

## GIVING UNTIL IT HURTS

**2 Samuel 24:18-25**

*"No," the king said to Araunah. "I will buy them from you at a fair price. I won't offer up to the LORD my God entirely burned offerings that cost me nothing." —2 Samuel 24:24*

### Commentary:

When David wanted to buy Araunah's land to build an altar, Araunah generously offered the land as a gift. However, David refused, insisting to pay a fair price for it because he wanted to offer a true sacrifice to God. The word *sacrifice* implies giving something that costs the giver one's self, time, or money. Giving sacrificially means more than a minimal effort and greater than a token gift. Giving to God what costs us nothing does not demonstrate true commitment. God asks us to give as God did. What can we give to God in return for the lives we are able to live?

### Questions to think about:

- ▶ Remembering that Araunah was willing to give King David whatever he wanted, are you willing to give to your King whatever he wants? Is there anything you fear he might take that you want to keep?
- ▶ Are you a sacrificial giver in terms of your time, talents, and treasures? If not, what holds you back?
- ▶ What is one sacrificial act you can offer this week out of love for God?

## WE BRING A SACRIFICE OF PRAISE

**Hebrews 13:1-16**

*Don't forget to do good and to share what you have because God is pleased with these kinds of sacrifices. —Hebrews 13:16*

### Commentary:

As Jews, some of the early believers had previously offered animal sacrifices to God to atone for their sins and bring God praise. The writer of Hebrews encourages believers, both past and present, to instead make acts of praise and service

# TEACHER BIBLE PREP

**LINC**  
LIVING IN CHRIST

## Ruins of a sacrificial altar in Israel

their sacrifices. These sacrifices do not require a burnt offering or an altar, and they can take place anytime and anywhere. God is pleased when we engage in intentional acts of kindness and service. God also is pleased when we are generous and give with a cheerful heart. God is certainly pleased when we make sacrifices of our time and treasures.

### Questions to think about:

- ▶ Reflecting on all God has done in your life and the blessings that may have gone unnoticed, even during this time of pandemic, what sacrifice of praise can you bring to God this week?
- ▶ What can you share this week with others as a sacrifice to God?

.....

**Acts of praise and service are sacrifices that do not require a burnt offering or an altar. They can take place anytime and anywhere.**

## DEVOTION: WORSHIP WHILE YOU WORK

Due to social distancing, many jobs have taken on a different look and approach. Teachers are meeting with students in virtual classrooms, creating online assignments, and focusing on grace over grades. People who are used to working in an office are working from home—many with the additional challenges of caring for and teaching children at the same time. Workers in utilities, food service, grocery, and healthcare are continuing to serve and are following additional safety precautions. Even serving as a youth leader is happening in a different format as we share our conversations and events via videoconferencing. Paul writes in Colossians 3:23-24:

*“Whatever you do, do it from the heart for the Lord and not for people. You know that you will receive an inheritance as a reward. You serve the Lord Christ.”*

Whatever form our work may take, let's remember to regard our work as an act of worship and service to God. When we choose to approach our work with a prayerful attitude (whether social distancing or not), we complain less and enjoy it more.

**NEXT WEEK:** Bored yet? It's easy for the days to run together during this time of quarantine. Next week in LINC we'll talk about how we can live with purpose during a tedious time at home.

LINC: Living in Christ is an official resource of The United Methodist Church approved by Discipleship Ministries and published by Youth Ministry Partners and Cokesbury: The United Methodist Publishing House, 2222 Rosa L. Parks Blvd., Nashville, TN 37228-1306.

Scripture quotations unless noted otherwise are taken from the Common English Bible, copyright 2011. Used by permission. All rights reserved.

Available by e-mail subscription by calling toll free: 800-672-1789. Also available for download from <https://www.cokesbury.com/linc?pagenumber=1>.

**Writer:** Tiffany Manning

**Editor:** Kevin Alton

**Production Editor:** Pam Shepherd

**Template Designer:** Micah Kandros

# PROCEED AT YOUR OWN RISK

**Getting Ready:** Ask students to gather the following items prior to the video call: a Bible, a note card or piece of paper, a pen or pencil, a glass of water, a sturdy piece of paper (poster board or card stock works best). If you didn't email Youth Page 6 to teens, ask them to collect an additional piece of paper for today's lesson.

## Before the Session:

- Fill a plastic glass with water and have available a sturdy piece of paper or poster board that will cover the top of the glass. Also have a plastic container to use under the glass in case of an accident.
- Watch this video of the opening science experiment and practice it a few times: [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AKHsJAY\\_peo](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AKHsJAY_peo). (Note to Leader: If you have mastered the experiment and want to add a level of personal risk, practice ahead of time placing your phone or head underneath the water glass after it is flipped.)
- On slips of paper, list common activities teens like to do and can still do while sheltering in place (watching movies, using Snapchat, texting, and so on) and number the back of each slip—one for each youth in your group.

## OPEN

### When the World Seems Upside Down (10 minutes)

Explain that you will conduct a science experiment, then step away from your computer to demonstrate, making sure teens can still see you on their screen. Show the full glass of water and ask (pausing between questions):

- ▶ Who believes I can flip over this glass of water and keep all the water inside simply by placing this piece of paper over the rim?
- ▶ Who would be willing to sit under this glass when I flip it over?
- ▶ Who would hold their phone underneath the glass?

After building suspense, place the paper on top of the rim, then in one quick motion, flip over the glass with your hand holding the paper underneath. Then remove your hand. The card will stick to the glass, keeping the water inside.

Say: "Sitting under this glass or holding your phone under it would involve taking a risk. Right now there are many people taking much larger risks since their jobs require close proximity to COVID-19. Today, as a tribute to all those who are risking illness each day to keep our country running, let's talk about weighing risks."

## EXPLORE

### Talk Topic 1: Putting Your Life on the Line (25 minutes)

#### Middle School Option

Ask, "Who has helped shape your self-image by showing you support and encouragement?" After some discussion, say: "Paul encouraged many of his fellow disciples of Christ in their work for Christ. Let's read the kind words he spoke about Timothy and Epaphroditus." Ask one or more teens to read aloud Philippians 2:19-30. After the Scripture reading, ask and talk about the following questions:

- ▶ Why was Epaphroditus visiting Paul when he was on house arrest?
- ▶ Considering the conditions in biblical times, what risks were involved in Epaphroditus' trip to deliver the supplies from Philippi?
- ▶ What happened to Epaphroditus upon his arrival in Rome?

Say: "Paul was especially grateful for Epaphroditus' willingness to take a risk and make the journey to care for him. Let's think about what uncomfortable action we can take this week to bring God glory."

Ask students to use Youth Page 6 or a blank sheet of paper and a pen or pencil to trace one hand on the paper. On each finger, ask teens to write one way they can step outside their comfort zones this week to show their love for God. After a few minutes, encourage students to show and tell their ideas.

#### High School Option

Ask, "Do you give praise easily, or do you find this hard to do? Why?" After a few responses, say, "In the Scripture we will read, Paul gives great praise to Timothy and Epaphroditus for their commitment to the Lord." Call on a volunteer or two to read aloud Philippians 2:19-30, then lead a conversation around the following questions:

- ▶ Who in your life is like Timothy who "genuinely cares about your well-being" (verse 20b)? What do they do to show they care?



# PROCEED AT YOUR OWN RISK



- ▶ Is there someone you know who is like Epaphroditus and would risk her or his life for the work of Christ?
- ▶ What is an example of something this person has done that reflects a willingness to take a risk for God's sake?

Follow the instructions for Youth Page 6 activity in the previous "Middle School Option."

## BONUS SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

Brainstorm a list of professions in which the work currently puts employees at risk because of COVID-19. Say, "While Epaphroditus chose to put his life on the line by delivering supplies to Paul, many people today do not have the luxury of choice."

Ask and talk about the following questions:

- ▶ Do you know someone who is having a difficult time going to work right now because of the dangers involved with COVID-19? What are the concerns?
- ▶ What aspects of student life are challenging to you right now due to current restrictions?
- ▶ What are some ways you are taking care of yourself, physically and emotionally, while facing the extra stresses related to COVID-19?

## Talk Topic 2: The Cost of Sacrifice (20 minutes)

### Middle School Option

Ask: "Who is the most generous person in your family? How does he or she show generosity to you?" After some sharing, say, "Our Old Testament story today is about a generous man named Araunah who wanted to give whatever he had to King David."

Read the Bible story as a readers theatre, asking students to play each of the following roles: narrator, Araunah, and David. After the reading, say: "Sacrifices come with a cost. Many workers today are taking a risk to do their job for others—and for some, the cost has been their lives. This week I'm challenging you to make a sacrifice in order to draw closer in your relationship with God."

Hold up the slips of paper prepared earlier so that teens can see the numbers. Ask each student to pick a number, then read aloud the activity stated.

Point out the challenge activity on Youth Page 6. Ask teens if they can give up any of the activities mentioned to spend more time with God. Then allow time for teens to fill in the blanks. Remember to follow up next week to see how youth met their challenges.

### High School Option

Ask: "Have you ever unexpectedly received something for free? If so, what was it? Did you insist on paying for it, or did you accept the gift?"

After a brief time of sharing, say, "In this Old Testament story, David insists on paying for the materials he needed to build an altar to offer sacrifices to God." Ask for a volunteer (or two) to read aloud 2 Samuel 24:18-25, then complete the weekly challenge activity on Youth Page 6 mentioned in the previous "Middle School Option."

## Talk Topic 3: Give Thanks with a Grateful Heart (20 minutes)

### Combined Middle School and High School Option

Ask: "Using only one word, how would you describe the relationship you have with your siblings? If you do not have any siblings, how would you describe your relationship with a cousin?"

After a time of sharing, say: "In Hebrews 13, the writer encourages us to keep loving one another like family. Let's see what else the author had to say to the early Christians that still applies to us today." Read aloud Hebrews 13:1-16, or ask several teens to take turns reading several verses each.

Say: "Let's do something helpful by creating thank-you notes for front-line workers we know who are putting their lives on the line each day for others when they go to work. As teens work, consider playing "Lifesong" by Casting Crowns at <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oEhlwljvOq0>. Encourage students to mail or drop off their notes during the coming week.

## TAKE AWAY

Close with a prayer for the safety, health, and courage of essential employees.

# WORKING IT OUT

## TAKE YOUR LIFE IN YOUR HANDS

Epaphroditus took his life in his hands when he made the journey to visit Paul while he was under house arrest. Trace your hand in the space below. On each finger, write one way you can take a risk this week to show your love for God. Examples might include sharing an encouraging Bible verse online, praying with a friend, or making plans to volunteer in a new way after safe-at-home restrictions are lifted.

### My Challenge for the Week

I will give up:

---

---

for at least one day.

In my extra time, I will spend time with God by:

---

---

### In the Bible: Readings for the Week

**MONDAY:** Read John 15:9-17

Jesus laid down his life for you. What can you give up for him?

**TUESDAY:** Read 2 Timothy 1:3-12.

What is making you feel timid or afraid right now?

**WEDNESDAY:** Read Acts 21:1-16.

What is the most difficult thing you have done for God?

**THURSDAY:** Read Matthew 6:25-34.

Who can you remind today that God will provide for their needs?

**FRIDAY:** Read Joshua 1:6-9.

What upcoming situation will require you to be courageous?

**SATURDAY:** Read Romans 12:1-8.

How can you give sacrificially of your unexpected free time in the coming week?



### Inherit the Mirth



### WHAT'S TRENDING?

When have you undertaken a real risk? Tweet or post your response with the hashtag #beingbrave on Twitter to @YMPartners or on facebook.com/youthministypartners